



Forbidden City

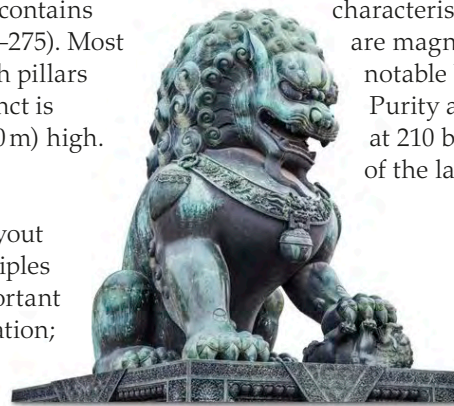
An iconic Chinese landmark and the world's largest, best-preserved, and most spectacular collection of wooden buildings

Home to the rulers of China's last two dynasties (the Ming and the Qing, 1368–1912), the Forbidden City in Beijing was built as a display of imperial power and is now one of the world's most important cultural centers. Constructed in c.1406–1420 and rebuilt over the centuries, the palace covers an area of 7,750,000 square ft (720,000 square m) and contains around 800 buildings (see pp.274–275). Most of the structures are wooden, with pillars crafted from huge logs. The precinct is surrounded by a vast wall 33 ft (10 m) high.

Design and feng shui

The location, architecture, and layout of the complex followed the principles of feng shui. One of its most important features is its north–south orientation; many of the principal buildings face south, in homage to the

Sun. Symmetrical in structure, the complex has an inner court—the imperial family's domestic space—and an outer court for state affairs. These areas include palaces, halls, towers, and pavilions, often with distinctive red walls and yellow roof tiles. Walls, railings, pillars, and roofs, with their characteristic upturned, overhanging eaves, are magnificently decorated. Among the many notable buildings are the Palace of Heavenly Purity and the Hall of Supreme Harmony—at 210 by 121 ft (64 by 37 m), the latter is one of the largest structures on the site.



◁ GUARDIAN LION

A magnificent gilded bronze lion with an ornamented sphere beneath his paw stands guard as a representative of imperial power and dignity in the Forbidden City.

The Forbidden City has **survived** more than **200 earthquakes**



△ ELABORATE ROOFS

The brightly colored rooftops in the Forbidden City have supporting beams and distinctive overhanging upturned eaves, beneath which are interlocking wooden roof brackets, or *dougong* (see panel, right).

THE CITY'S ROOFS

The elaborate roofs of the Forbidden City are supported by an ingenious system of wooden brackets, which can be assembled without using nails or glue. They provide a strong, flexible structure that allows the buildings to withstand regular earthquakes. Wooden blocks known as *dou* are placed onto the building's columns; further brackets (*gong*) are slotted into the *dou*. Multiple units of *dougong* below are compressed by the weight of the roof, making a robust structure.

